

EVIDENCE BRIEFING FOR A DIRECTOR

Brand visibility inside AI assistants: what the evidence supports

Is there real demand, per buyer segment, for brands to be named or recommended by artificial intelligence (AI) assistants such as ChatGPT, Gemini, Perplexity, Copilot and Claude? And what evidence shows it works?

Research only: evidence, not a verdict

Evidence as of 2026-09

Sources pulled 2026-09-22 and 2026-09-23. A figure without its own date carries its pull date.

THE ANSWER FIRST

Engines are selling AI placement and some large buyers spend, but no published case shows it pays back

\$1 billion

ChatGPT ads: "annualized revenue run rate"

company-stated, 2026-08-31

8 of 27

buyer segments show spend (strict reading; a loose reading and an earlier count also exist)

analyst-derived, 2026-09-23

0 of ~980

screened published cases used a controlled design

measured-by-us, 2026-09-22

27 of 27

segments: price any buyer paid is unknown

analyst-derived, 2026-09-23

The evidence supports "**some large firms are spending.**" It stops short of "**it pays back.**" No sub-market has a measured size, and no buyer discloses a price paid.

Supply is proven, demand is visible but thin, and proof of effect is missing. The rest of this deck shows each of those three reads and where it stops.

Every figure carries a source kind and a tier; the lower the tier, the stronger the source

Tier	Source
1	Measured by the research team itself
2	Filed: regulatory filing, court exhibit, funding filing
3	A platform's own documents, changelog, pricing page
4	Panel, clickstream or telemetry data
5	Vendor or agency study stating sample, dates, method
6	Vendor blog without sample size: marketing
7	Listicle or roundup: not used

Source kinds

filed · **company-stated** · **vendor-reported** · **analyst-derived** (compiled by the research team from other sources) · **measured-by-us**

Grades for published success cases

- **Gold**: holdout, geo-split or switchback design. Causal.
- **Silver**: before/after with baseline and an unaffected control. Correlational.
- **Bronze**: visibility or mention change only.

WHAT THIS IS

Brands want to be named when someone asks an AI assistant what to buy; the market splits three ways

Organic recommendation

Being mentioned or cited in the answer **without paying the engine**.

Who sells: software vendors and agencies selling tools and services to raise mentions.

Paid placement

Ads in or beside AI answers, sold by the engines themselves.

Who sells: the assistant operators (for example ChatGPT's owner OpenAI, Google).

Agentic commerce

The assistant **completes the purchase** for the user.

Who sells: engines running checkout inside the assistant.

The three are sized, sold and measured differently. Figures from one are never added to, or compared on an axis with, another.

WHY NOW

Since 2026-02, engines opened ad inventory, and regulators and courts moved in

●	2026-02-04	Anthropic: "Claude will remain ad-free"	company-stated, tier 3
●	2026-02-09	ChatGPT ads go live, United States (US) pilot	company-stated, tier 3
●	2026-03-25	Amazon Rufus sponsored prompts generally available, US	company-stated, tier 3
●	2026-05-19	Google AI Mode "1B MAU" (monthly active users); AI Overviews 2.5B users	company-stated, tier 3
○	2026-08-02	European Union (EU) AI Act Art. 50 transparency duties in force	filed, tier 2
●	2026-08-31	ChatGPT ads "\$1 billion" run rate; ChatGPT >1B weekly users	company-stated, tier 3
○	2026-08-31	EU designates ChatGPT a very large search engine: 159.1M EU recipients	filed, tier 2
●	2026-09-15	Profound (visibility vendor) raises "\$180M Series D at \$1.8B valuation"	vendor-reported, tier 3
○	2026-09-17	Court filing: Microsoft data shows "83-93% drops in click-through rates"	filed, tier 2

Solid dot: company or vendor statement. Open dot: filed document.

A hypothetical visibility product rests on eight assumptions; the strongest evidence for any is tier 3

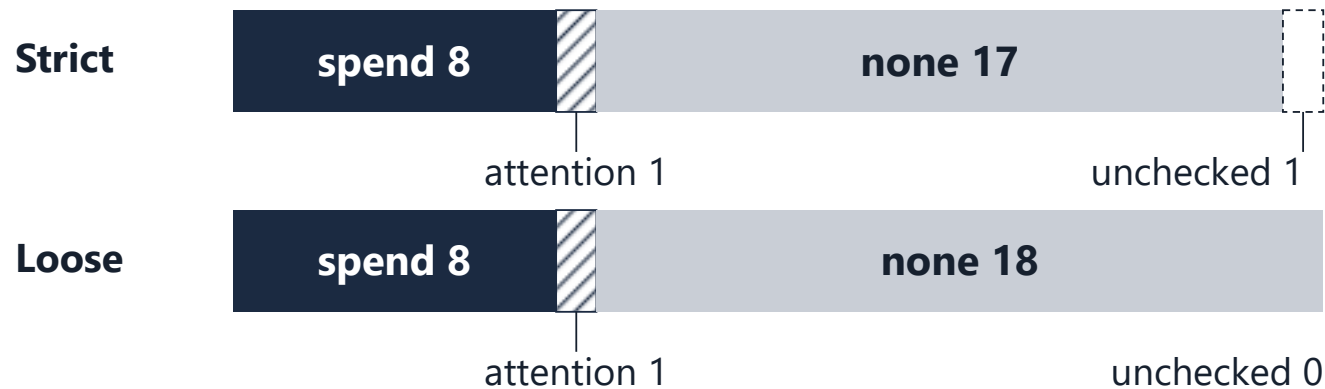
Assumption	Category	What the evidence shows	Source, tier
Buyers spend now	Market	8 of 27 segments show spend (2026-09-23)	analyst-derived, tier 5 floor
Spend reaches small firms	Customer	1 of 9 small and mid-sized business (SMB) segments (2026-09-22)	analyst-derived, tier 3
Buyers disclose what they pay	Economic	<i>unknown</i> in 27 of 27 segments (2026-09-23)	none found
The market has a measured size	Economic	15 of 18 published figures are forecasts; 0 measured sizes	tier 6
Intervention lifts sales	Operational	0 Gold (controlled-design) cases	vendor-reported cases, tier 5
AI visitors convert better	Customer	Adobe: "AI Conversion Now 42% Higher" (2026-03)	vendor-reported, tier 4
Engines leave room for third parties	Competitive	Copilot runs own checkout, "does not take a commission" (2026-01)	company-stated, tier 3
Engines keep inventory open	Competitive	5 of 8 engines sell ads; Claude refuses	company-stated, tier 3

A hypothesis, not a plan. The next slides open the three that bear the load: buyers pay, it works, platforms leave room.

LOAD-BEARING ASSUMPTION 1: BUYERS PAY

8 of 27 buyer segments show spend under both readings; most show none

Buyer segments (count), 27 per reading, as of 2026-09-23



Bar length = number of segments, full bar = 27.

- A segment is one buyer vertical (skincare and beauty; business-to-business (B2B) software; regulated sectors with high cost per acquisition) × sub-market × company size.
- **Strict** counts "none" only if every signal ran; **loose** counts a blocked, logged channel as checked. Attention: interest seen, no spend.
- Earlier count, 2026-09-22: 7 spend segments, 5 enterprise; six rest on job postings, not purchases. Same split for the 8: *unknown — not in repo*.
- Small firms: 1 of 9 SMB segments shows spend (2026-09-22).

No published case proves a sales effect: none of ~980 screened used a controlled design

~980 published cases screened (measured-by-us, 2026-09-22)

Gold, causal: 0

Silver, correlational: 7 as graded, or 1 under the literal grading rule. Both stand. Two of the seven run negative or null. Every positive Silver is tier 5.

Brand confirmation: 0 of 59 brands checked corroborate their vendor's case; ~107 unchecked.

Nearest signals, and their limits

- Adobe: "AI Conversion Now 42% Higher" than non-AI visits (vendor-reported, tier 4, 2026-03). Conversion of visitors, not a controlled lift.
- An advertiser's own test of ChatGPT ads: click-through rate (CTR) 1.30%, "very few sign-ups" (vendor-reported, tier 5, 2026-08).

Published cases are survivors: failures rarely get a case study.

No sub-market has a measured size; 15 of 18 published figures are forecasts

Organic

Floor from disclosed revenue
\$42.2M–\$48.2M + €2.2M annual
recurring revenue (ARR), 4 vendors,
2025-11 to 2026-05

filed, tier 2; company-stated, tier 5

Beside it, price × customer-count build:
\$5.3M–\$35.2M

Published forecast, 2034
\$17.15B–\$32.92B
analyst-derived, tier 6

Paid

Floor from disclosed revenue
≥ \$1B run rate, one engine
company-stated, 2026-08-31

Published forecasts, 2030
~\$5B–\$100B+, a spread of ~20×
analyst-derived; scopes differ

Agentic

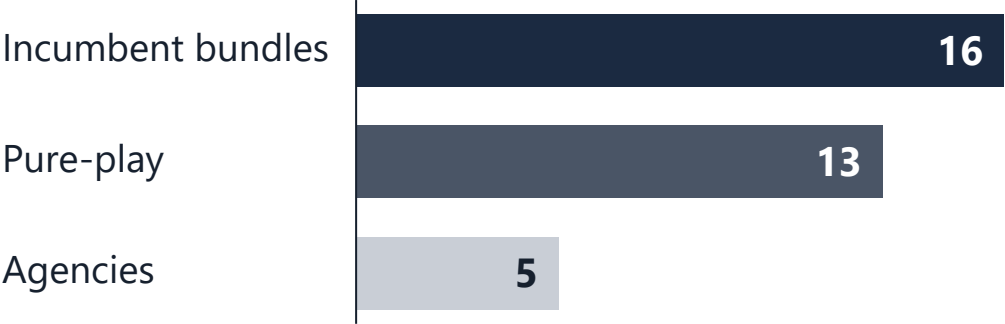
Floor: agent-executed sales
unknown — checked 2026-09-23

Published forecasts, 2030
\$190B–\$5T, a spread of 26.3×
analyst-derived, tier 5–6
Another file reads the spread as
"roughly 35×".

The three columns measure different things and years; they are not comparable with each other.

34 vendors sell visibility tools; 14 disclose a price and only 2 file revenue

Vendors on the roster (count), 34 in total



analyst-derived roster; bar length = vendor count

- Price disclosed by 14 of 34: "\$20/mo" to "\$999/month" (vendor-reported, 2026-09).
- Filed revenue: 2 of 34, neither broken out to this product.

Signal	Source, date
Semrush: "AI products surpassed \$38 million in ARR"	filed, 2026-03-02
Peec AI: \$10M ARR (earlier figure: \$4M)	vendor-reported, 2026-05 (2025-11)
Profound: "\$180M Series D at \$1.8B valuation"	vendor-reported, 2026-09-15
Scrunch acquired by Sitecore; value undisclosed by Sitecore	company-stated, 2026-06-03
Same deal: \$225M per Bloomberg, unconfirmed	relayed press, undated

Money is flowing into vendors. What vendors' own customers pay, and whether it pays them back, is not disclosed.

Engines hold the inventory: 5 of 8 sell ads, none publishes a rate card, and checkout is theirs

Paid placement



Filled: engine sells ads (5 of 8). Open: does not.

- Claude refuses ads: "Claude will remain ad-free" (2026-02-04).
- Rate cards published: 0 of 8. Only stated price: OpenAI max-bid guidance "\$3–\$5 USD per click" (US dollars).
- OpenAI: "more than 50 technology and measurement partners" (2026-08-31).

Checkout inside the assistant



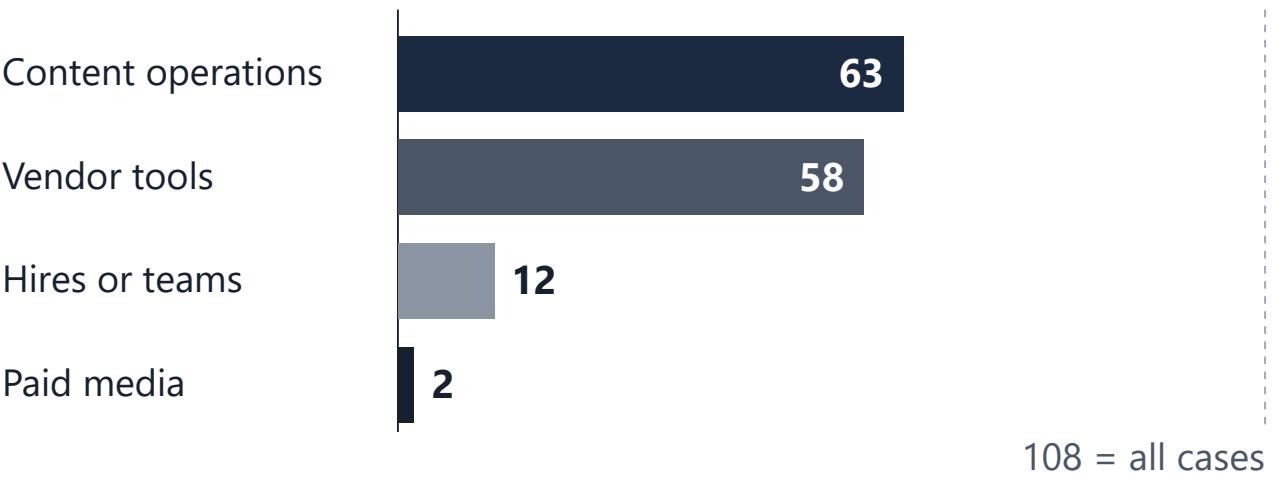
4 live; fee disclosed by 1 of 4. Dashed: not disclosed.

- Live: ChatGPT, Google, Copilot, Perplexity.
- Copilot runs its own checkout and "does not take a commission" (2026-01).
- Fee clauses in checkout protocols: 6 of 6 *unknown — checked 2026-09-22*.

WHAT BRANDS THAT MOVED CHANGED

Brands that acted mostly rewrote content and bought tools; 2 of 108 bought paid media

Cases naming each kind of change (count, of 108; one case can name several)



- Both paid cases are Google's Direct Offers pilot (e.l.f., L'Oréal).
- 57 of 58 tool cases rest on vendor pages.
- How many moved a metric: 67 of 108 (reading of 2026-09-23). Another reading counts 99 of 108 naming a change. Both stand.

Evidence of activity, not of payback: the counts come from self-reports.

Of 11 ranked risks, the top one is the AI answer replacing the click

Rank	Risk	Evidence	Source, date
1	Referral collapse: the answer replaces the click	NerdWallet cards revenue "decreased 24%"	filed, 2026-02-25
2	Regulation	United Kingdom (UK) fair-ranking rule covers "search generative AI features"	filed, 2026-06-17
3	Vendor consolidation	Semrush merged into Adobe, "\$12.00/share cash"	filed, 2026-04-28
4	Platform capture	OpenAI: "more than 50 technology and measurement partners"	company-stated, 2026-08-31
5	No payback evidence	Advertiser test: CTR 1.30%, "very few sign-ups"	vendor-reported, tier 5, 2026-08

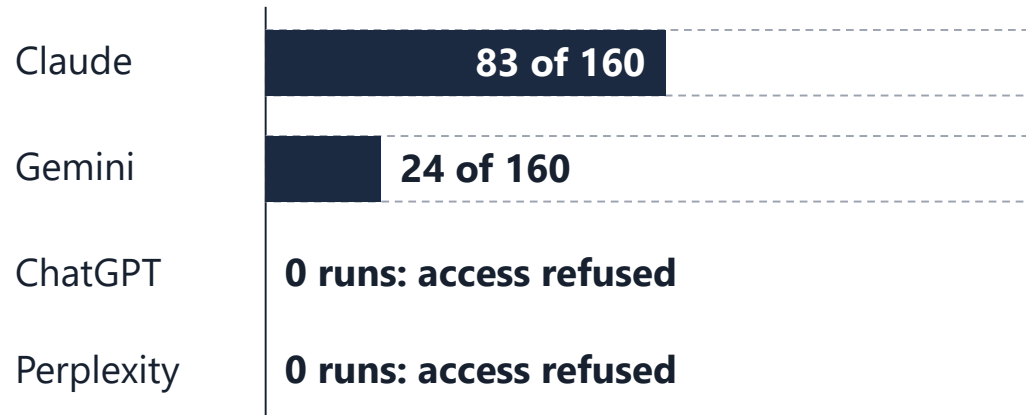
Likelihood, impact and mitigation: **no source states one.** The ranking is the research team's (2026-09-23); the lower-ranked risks sit in the full register.

Risk 1 has a second filed signal: a court filing citing Microsoft data on "83-93% drops in click-through rates" (2026-09-17).

WHERE THE EVIDENCE STOPS

The evidence stops at price paid, direct measurement of assistant answers, and brand confirmation

Our own sampling of assistant answers (runs completed), stopped 2026-09-22 22:40 at a partial first day



Bar = runs completed; dashed outline = 160 runs.

- Price paid by any buyer: *unknown* in 27 of 27 segments.
- Brand confirmation of vendor cases: 0 of 59 brands checked corroborate; ~107 unchecked.
- Agent-executed sales: *unknown* — *checked 2026-09-23*.
- Job-board and analyst market-size channels (indeed.com, emarketer.com): still blocked 2026-09-23.

The hard questions, answered only from the evidence

"\$1 billion of ChatGPT ads proves demand, surely?"

It proves one engine sells ads (company-stated, 2026-08-31). Which buyers pay what: unknown in 27 of 27 segments.

"AI visitors convert 42% better. Isn't that proof?"

Vendor-reported, tier 4, 2026-03, and not a controlled test. Gold cases: 0.

"Will the engines leave room for anyone else?"

Unclear. OpenAI cites "more than 50" partners; Copilot's checkout "does not take a commission"; 0 of 8 publish rate cards.

"Investors put \$180M into Profound. Isn't that validation?"

It validates investor appetite (vendor-reported, 2026-09-15). Filed revenue exists for 2 of 34 vendors, neither broken out.

"Is this only for big companies?"

So far, largely. 1 of 9 SMB segments shows spend; 5 of the 7 earlier spend segments were enterprise (2026-09-22).

"Why not just measure the answers yourselves?"

It started and stopped at a partial first day: Claude 83 of 160 runs, Gemini 24 of 160, ChatGPT and Perplexity 0.

WHAT THIS ASKS OF YOU

The verdict is yours; these are the readings any verdict would rest on

Question	Reading A	Reading B
Demand	Strict: 8 spend, 17 none, 1 unchecked	Loose: 8 spend, 18 none, 0 unchecked
Proof	7 Silver cases as originally graded	1 Silver under the literal grading rule
Movers	67 of 108 moved a metric	99 of 108 name a change
Size	Floors from disclosed revenue only	Forecasts only; 0 measured sizes

What the evidence supports

Engines sell placement; some large firms spend; vendors raise and consolidate.

Where it stops

Price paid, measured size, sales effect, small-firm demand.

Asked of you

Nothing beyond the call itself. The research gives evidence, not a go/no-go.

CAVEATS

Read every figure here as a statement by an interested party unless marked filed or measured-by-us

- Prices, customer counts, funding and success cases are vendor or company statements, unaudited.
- Published cases are survivors; failures rarely get written up.
- Measured-by-us data cover one date, from one network location.
- Two readings exist for several figures (demand, proof, movers); both are shown, neither averaged.
- Forecasts are not measurements; they are shown by sub-market and never added across sub-markets.
- Evidence stops at 2026-09-23. Nothing later is included.

Glossary

- **AI:** artificial intelligence. **AI Mode, AI Overviews:** Google's AI answer surfaces in Search.
- **ARR:** annual recurring revenue. **Run rate:** current revenue scaled to a year, as stated by the company.
- **B2B:** business-to-business.
- **CPA:** cost per acquisition (of a customer).
- **CTR:** click-through rate.
- **EU, UK, US:** European Union, United Kingdom, United States. **USD:** US dollars.
- **MAU:** monthly active users.
- **SMB:** small and medium-sized business.
- **Engine:** an AI assistant or answer surface (ChatGPT, Gemini, Perplexity, Copilot, Claude, Google AI Mode, Amazon Rufus).
- **Segment:** buyer vertical × sub-market × company size.
- **Spend / attention / none:** a segment's read. Attention never stands in for spend.
- **Strict / loose reading:** strict counts "none" only if every signal ran; loose counts a blocked, logged channel as checked.
- **Gold / Silver / Bronze:** case grades; see slide 3.
- **Tier:** provenance score written on every source; lower is stronger; see slide 3.

Paired readings: both kept, neither averaged

Figure	Reading A	Reading B
Spend segments	7 of 27, 2026-09-22	8 strict, 8 loose, 2026-09-23
None / unchecked segments	strict 17 / 1, 2026-09-23	loose 18 / 0, 2026-09-23
Silver cases	7 as graded, undated	1 under grading rule 1, undated
Peec AI ARR	\$4M, 2025-11	\$10M, 2026-05
Scrunch deal value	undisclosed (Sitecore), 2026-06-03	\$225M (Bloomberg), unconfirmed
Skincare agentic, enterprise	spend, undated	attention, undated
Agentic forecast spread	26.3× (2030)	"roughly 35×" (2029–2030 horizon)
Cases that moved	99 of 108 name a change, 2026-09-23	67 metric-moved, 37 action-only, 4 neither, 2026-09-23